

The Cuban Revolution

In 1959, Cuban revolutionary Fidel Castro and a small group of rebels seized control of Cuba, ending the brutal dictatorship of Fulgencio Batista. Their new government made many reforms, improving the health care and education systems in the country.

Fidel Castro was the son of a wealthy farmer, and developed an interest in politics while studying law in Havana, Cuba's capital. He started a campaign to overthrow Batista, but his first attempt to do so in 1953 failed. In 1956, Castro began a second military campaign in the mountains of eastern Cuba, which by 1958 had gained considerable ground. The following January, Castro overthrew Batista and took power.

The Cuban Revolution brought huge social and economic changes to the island. The government transformed the economy and took control of land ownership. Cuba also supported revolutionaries in other

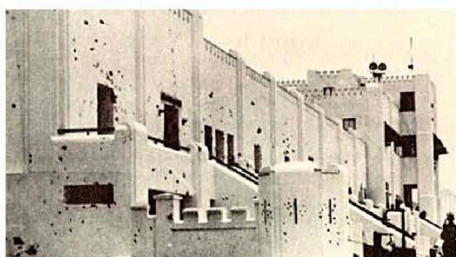
BATISTA'S CUBA ►

Fulgencio Batista seized power in a military coup in 1952 and ruled until 1959. During this time, 20,000 people were killed and many others tortured. Government corruption was so great that in 1957, even the US government, an ally, withheld military aid, and for a time supported Castro's resistance movement.

Latin American nations and sent troops to fight against colonialism and apartheid in Africa. After the government took over US oil facilities on the island, the US banned trade with Cuba. Following a failed invasion sponsored by the US in 1961, Cuba allied itself more closely with the USSR.



1900 TO PRESENT

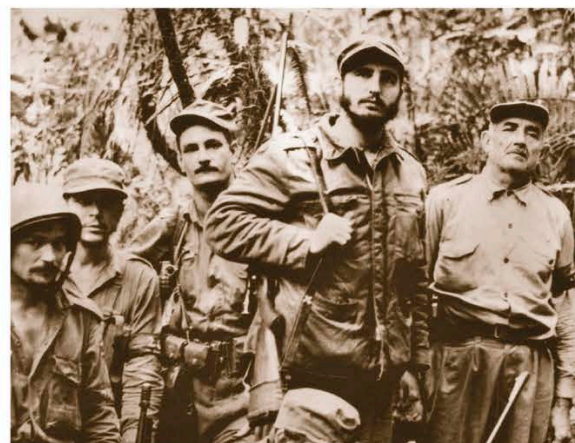


▲ MONCADA BARRACKS

In 1952, as a young lawyer, Fidel Castro ran for parliament but the elections were canceled after Batista seized power. On May 26, 1953, Castro led an attack by 135 rebels on the Moncada military barracks in the city of Santiago de Cuba. The attack failed and Castro was imprisoned until 1955.

CASTRO'S RETURN ►

After a year in exile in Mexico, Castro returned to Cuba along with 82 fighters in December 1956. All but 20 were killed in an ambush on arrival but the survivors set up a base in Cuba's Sierra Maestra mountains from which they then began another armed struggle to overthrow Batista.



REVOLUTIONARY VICTORY ►

As leader, Castro converted Cuba into a communist country (one where wealth is supposed to be shared among the people). He improved conditions for the poor, and provided better access to hospitals and schools. Yet Castro also went on ban any opposition to his rule, becoming a dictator himself.

